Mao's Concept of Guerrilla Warfare

by B. N. Majumdar

Mao Tse-tung is the foremost Chinese military strategist. He has not attended any military school or college, nor has he donned any military uniform of the regular army. He has never been through the doors of any military academy, nor is he a graduate of a Staff College or Defence College. In spite of these seemingly professional disqualifications, he is revered and respected as the foremost Chinese military strategist, whose writings are best sellers in the world today, who is studied throughout the world as the authority on irregular warfare and who is perhaps even putting Confucius and Sun Tzu, the pioneers of ancient military literature, in the shade.

Mao had his grooming in the hard school of practical soldiering. Since his arrival on the arena of Chinese politics he has guided the destinies of millions of Chinese ever since he took part in the Long March, fought the Japanese and the Kuomintang and finally took over the reins of government in 1949.

Communist China's rise is being felt in all spheres of activity in Southeast Asia. Many countries have felt the pressure of her clandestine activities around their borders but do not scream about it much, perhaps because of the fear of her military strength. Mao's ideas and strategies have been behind all Chinese expansionist activities in Asia. It is, therefore, incumbent on all of us to study critically the underlying and hidden meaning of Mao's sayings, ideas and conclusions.

Mao Tse-tung's main military writings are contained in Volume 2 of his selected works (though some are found in Volume 4). It will be interesting to note that Mao's concepts of warfare were formulated during the various stages of his sttuggle against the Japanese. But these still hold good today and are apparently being implemented in the various small wars now being fought around China's periphery.

Because of the military expediency of the anti-Japanese struggle Mao propagated the idea of guerrilla warfare whereby the whole people would become fully engulfed in the struggle. It had to be so because the regular army of the Kuomintang was a degenerate corrupt force.

Mao noted that some ills of the Kuomintang army had to be eradicated before people participated in the war with full enthusiasm. The people could be aroused only by their active participation. And guerrilla war was the best means of ensuring this participation. Of course, there were other reasons warranting the organisation of guerrila warfare. The chief of these was that the Chinese Army was in no way equipped to take on the Japanese in pitched battles. But the main reason was the involvement of the people.

For waging guerrilla war successfully it was necessary to enlist the political support of the people and this gave an opportunity to the Communists to preach to the people their faith and their way of life. This also enabled them to inject political norms and ideas into what would be purely military organisation.

Politico-military Policy

In order to meet the Japanese offensive, the Chinese Communist Party formulated some important politico-military policies. It recommended a general mobilisation of the Army, Navy and the Air Force of the

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whole country. Troops were also to be deployed for the protection of rear areas.

Among the purely military measures the choice of leaders was very important. The military commands were to be entrusted to "generals who are loyal to the national interest". This meant various things. It meant that the generals had to have a party bias so that the "political work of the army" could be reformed in keeping with the overall political concept of the Communist Party. It also meant that there was to be "unity between officers and men and unity between the army and the people", that the strategic directives should be issued "to assure unity of aim in military operations", that "guerrilla warfare should account for a part of the strategic task in co-ordination with regular warfare", that "collaborators" be weeded out, that suitable steps be taken to mobilise reserves and train them for the front, and that, finally, adequate logistical arrangements be made to "replenish, on a reasonable basis, the equipment and supplies of the armed forces".

The concept of modern war is all-embracing. It concerns the military as well as the people. People's cooperation is as important as military action by the fighting forces. Mao understood that the best means to ensure people's cooperation was to improve their lot. By 'people' Mao did not mean merely factory workers and workers of defence industries; he meant every individual man, woman and child. Mao propounded that the combined strength of the people and the army would be able to deal a deadly blow to the enemy.

Mao correctly estimated that in order to rouse the people some ground had to be found as the rallying point of their spirit. For Mao it was class struggle. So he sought to bring people actively into the class struggle. He further knew that "beyond doubt, we can win no victory in a national war without relying on the great masses of the people". So he propounded the cause of national liberation. Mao combined social revolution with national liberation and aroused the enthusiasm of the entire population.

It was throughout visualised by Mao that in order to avoid subversion from within the armed forces must be based on their political loyalty to the regime, that political loyalty was vital for the success of the communsiation of the country, and that ideological success would never be possible without political co-operation of the armed forces. From the very outset Mao thought it prudent to keep control over the armed forces through political guidance. After all political power emanated from the 'barrel of a gun'. The source of power and strength of the regime rested in the Armed forces. Hence emphasis on political control of the army.

Mao realised that without the willing participation of the Armed forces the national cause would not triumph. Therefore, in addition to various political, economic and social reforms he advocated that soldiers must get rise in pay and that good care of their families should be taken when they were away fighting on the battlefield.

Policy and Strategy

To achieve unity of purpose during the formative stage and the period of struggle, it was vital that the armed forces were kept under the control of the political party, at least till consolidation was complete. It is quite possible that Mao had it in mind to run the armed forces of Communist China through the political machinery of the State as an integral part of the Party machinery. He started by advocating complete integration of the politico-military machine of the state and whole-hearted participation in the struggle by the people.

Perhaps the most interesting and

thought-provoking part of the military writings of Mao is that devoted to the enunciation of the theory and practice of guerrilla warfare. This treatise has become the bible of guerrilla war throughout the world today, and many have based their work on the main ideas of this book, though, perhaps with certain modifications to suit the local conditions and idiosyncracies of the people.

Though guerrilla wars have been fought in all parts of the world throughout history very few leaders have recorded experiences in such a clear and methodical manner as Mao Tse-tung has. There is no doubt that Mao was influenced in his ideas by the military, political, social and economic conditions which existed at the time in China. This made Mao realise that in an undeveloped country like his where distances were vast, communications undeveloped and non-existing, social and economic conditions feudal, and people slumbering, there was no other way but to stage guerrilla war with the sympathy and support of the people.

Strategic considerations

There is a mistaken belief on the part of certain proponents of guerrilla warfare that it can win wars without regular operations and this has been mainly ascribed to Mao Tse-tung. This is wrong. Mao has categorically stated that "guerrilla warfare would also merely play a co-ordinating role in the campaigns".

Guerrilla warfare will always play a role subsidiary to the regular warfare. It will supplement but will never win the war by itself. Therefore, the conduct of guerrilla operations must be closely co-ordinated with the operations of the regular army.

Though the problems of guerrilla warfare are merely tactical, there were some strategic considerations which were specially applicable in the conditions of China. China was a big and weak country being attacked by a small but strong country. The struggle would be protracted for obvious reasons. To succeed against such an attack, when native conditions were not conducive to the efficient conduct of war, the answer was "primarily not to co-ordinate with the regular troops in their campaigns on the interior line, but to fight independently on exterior line".

There were also "the problems of the base areas, of the development of guerrilla warfare into mobile warfare". Also one had to remember that wars would not only be long drawn but that there would also be small-scale, well-dispersed, short and intermittent conflicts.

Mao emphasised one basic principle for the conduct of guerrilla war and he considered that all others were mere corollaries to the basic principle. This was "to strive as far as possible to preserve one's own strength and annihilate that of the enemy".

Keeping in view this main principle, Mao propagated six other principles. Their principal point was that in addition to their self-preservation, the guerrilla forces must expand and develop in order to reach a stature when they could take on the regular army of the enemy and fight pitched battles. The essential points of this whole strategy were preservation and expansion of the guerrilla forces, annihilation and ousting of the enemy, and co-ordination with the operations of the regular army.

Many other tactical guide-lines were enunciated within the frame-work of the main principles. Some of these have been expounded in sufficient detail. But on the whole they depend on sound common sense, ready wit and willingness to act on the spur of the moment.

Throughout the treatise Mao has repeatedly emphasised the political aspect of the struggle. In planning and conducting guerrilla operations, political considerations

were to be given the pride of place even over purely military considerations.

Strategical Concepts and Tactical Ideas

The main strategical concepts of guerrilla war emphasised by Mao are initiative, flexibility, thorough planning, conduct of offensive operations in a defensive war, battles of quick decision in a protracted war, exterior line operations within interior line operations, co-ordination of guerrilla actions with regular warfare, establishment of base areas, development of guerrrilla operations into mobile warfare, and, finally, harmonious command relationship for smooth conduct of war in all spheres.

Within the framework of these main strategfcal concepts many other minor, though important, tactical concepts have been propounded.

Mao introduced some interesting tactical ideas. Some of his oft-quoted important maxims are: "In guerrilla operations concentration of the biggest possible force, secret and swift action, suprise attacks on the enemy and quick division in battles are required, while passive defence procrastination and dispersion of forces immediately before combat must be carefully avoided"; "The basic principle of guerrilla warfare must be one of offensive; such offensives must take the form of surprise attacks"; "Gather a big force to strike at a small enemy segment"; "Simultaneously expedite and await the changes of the international situation as well as the enemy's collapse from within, so as to launch a strategic counter-offensive"; "Any army that loses its initiative will be forced into a passive position and deprived of its freedom of action, and will run the risk of being exterminated or defeated"; "They (guerrillas) can appear and disappear mysteriously in the enemy's rear and completely baffle him"; "The initiative is not the natural gift of a genius, but something achieved by an intelligent leader who studies with a receptive mind and makes correct estimations of objective conditions and correct military and political dispositions"; "The ability to run away is precisely one of the characteristics of the guerrillas"; "Flexible employment of forces is more indispensable in guerrilla warfare than in regular warfare"; "In employing the guerrilla units, the director of guerrilla war is like a fisherman casting a net which he should be able to spread out as well as to draw in"; "Dispersion, concentration and shifting of the forces are the three ways of flexibility employing the forces in guerrilla warfare"; "If the enemy's forces at a place are particularly strong, the guerrilla units should not stay there long"; "In general, the shifting of forces should be done secretly and swiftly. Ingeneous devices such as making a noise in the east while attacking in the west, appearing now in the south and now in the north, hit-and-run and night action should be constantly employed to mislead, entice and confuse the enemy"; "The offensive is the only means of annihilating the enemy as well as the principal means of preserving oneself, while pure defence and withdrawal can play only a temporary and partial role in preserving oneself and are utterly useless in annihilating the enemy"; "We must spread a guerrilla war all over the vast enemy-occupied area, converting the enemy's rear into his front and forcing him to fight ceaselessly throughout his occupied areas"; "The build-up of an armed force is the most fundamental link in establishing a base area; without an armed force or with one that is not strong enough, nothing can be done"; "The armed forces should be employed in co-ordination with the masses of the people to defeat the enemy"; "Conservatism in guerrilla warfare must be opposed"; "In our dispositions we should contain a number of enemy columns with our supple-

mentary forces, and use our main force to attack a single enemy column by springing surprise attacks on it in campaigns and battles (mainly in the form of ambushes) and striking it while it is on the move"; "A leader in a guerrilla war should not think of abandoning his present base area and shifting to another, unless many attempts have been made to smash the enemy's vigorous converging attacks and it is conclusively shown that they cannot be smashed there"; "It is necessary to give the troops rest and training, and the best time for this is when the enemy is on the defensive"; "To raise the quality of the guerrilla units we must improve them politically and organisationally and along the lines of their equipment, military training, tactics and discipline, gradually remoulding them on the pattern of the regular army and reducing their guerrilla style in work. Politically it is imperative to make both the commanders and the rank and file realise the necessity of raising the guerrilla units to the level of the regular army, to encourage all of them to strive towards this end, and to guarantee its realisation by means of political work"; "The more extensive the area, the more complex the situation and the greater the distance between the higher-ups and the lower ranks, the more advisable it becomes to allow greater independence and initiative to the lower ranks, to give their actions more of a local nature and make them more adapted to the demands of local conditions, so that we can cultivate in the local ranks and among the local personnel the ability for independent work, tackle complicated situations and develop a victorious guerrilla war".

It will be seen from the foregoing quotations that there was a complete fusion between strategical and tactical ideas, one overlapping the other without much clear-cut distinction. Perhaps this was inevitable, coming as it did from a political thinker.

Mao propounded new ideas about strategy and tactics. He had read history and had learnt from past experience of his own country. Therefore, he could draw profusely tactical ideas for efficient conduct of guerrilla warfare. Perhaps he had also borrowed ideas from the experiences of Lenin and Stalin.

Mao is repetitive in his ideas, though perhaps this serves to emphasise certain aspects of his views. It will also be noted that, though guerrilla war was important; Mao thought of waging regular warfare to defeat the enemy on the battlefield. It would never have been possible to defeat the Japanese totally unless regular war was conducted in addition to guerrilla war. Mao did not seem to lose sight of this aspect though he had profusely theorised on guerrilla war in his many writings and treatises.

Operations on the flanks and in the rear seem to be the watchword of Chinese tactical concepts. This is clear from the experiences so far obtained from contacts with the Chinese in Korea, Indo-China, the Indian border and also from their own civil war. Outflanking movements and infiltration into the rear, specialised by the Chinese troops, seem to be unmatched so far by any other eastern or western armies.

Political Indoctrination

Historically China has often been a politically corrupt nation. Under feudal overlords the relations between officers, men and the people were not too happy. There was no unity of purpose between officers and men, discipline was almost non-existent and officers beat and bullied their men in a most inhuman manner.

Similarly, the relationship between the army and the people was far from happy. People had no confidence in the army because the officers looted and raped the

people who were uttenly helpless and poor. Furthermore, the army was kept aloof from the people; they never took any part in the activities of the state. All this was not conducive to the healthy growth of the people's cooperation with the army. Mao set about to correct this state of affairs and laid down strict rules to be observed by the guerrillas and the regular army troops.

Mao also gave much thought to the problem of the prisoners of war. He considered that "our victory depends not only upon the exploits of our troops but also upon the disintegration of the enemy troops." With a view to achieve this, Mao propounded the idea of "lenient treatment to prisoners of war" so that the enemy forces would be gradually disintegrated, thus rendering their army impotent.

Mao said, "we shall neither insult them nor brow-beat them, but explain to them the harmony between the interests of the people of the two countries, set them free and let them go home." This was a subtle psychological method to win their sympathy to the communist cause and convince them of the wrongness of the cause they were fighting for. Similarly, Mao thought of and practised political indoctrination of the prisoners of war.

The important thing was to collect recruits and reinforcements for the communist armies not by forcing the people but by encouraging them to join without compulsion. This gained not only popular sympathy and active collaboration of the people but also soldiers to fight for the communist cause.

Conclusion

Mao fully visualised the real implicatlon and magnitude of the conflicts. He felt that guerrilla fighting would be a protracted war and that the people and the government must be partners in this venture. There was no question of conflict merely between two armies; it would be a war between two nations, two peoples and two governments. Mao realised that unless the people fully parricipated in this conflict there could be no victory.

But before people took active part in such a war, the right atmosphere must be created. There must exist the best of relations between the people, the army, the government and the party. Unless these functioned harmoniously and with complete understanding it would be difficult to give the conflict a popular character. Mao has made these the main tasks of the party.

Himalayan States

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to India in respect of their foreign policy and defence. It is reported that China did "approach the Bhutanese with an offer to negotiate a border agreement, also to recognize Bhutan's sovereignty, to extend diplomatic recognition and to provide technical aid".[2] These efforts have not succeeded. China has not recognised India's treaty rights both in Bhutan and Sikkim. The Chinese ultimatum to India during the Indo-Pakistan war about the so-called installations in Sikkim is wellknown. China did not carry out the threats probably because of a possible Indian retaliation. Another factor which seems to prevent China from attempting physical absorption of these areas is its possible repurcussions on Nepal. It would seem that China

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[2] George Patterson : Recent Chinese Policies in Tibet and Towards the Himalayan Border States. *China Quarterly* No. 12 October-December 1962. (p. 199).